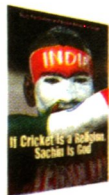


Defending the Deity

Two ardent worshippers celebrate Indian cricket's enduring wonder



IF CRICKET IS A RELIGION, SACHIN IS GOD

by VIJAY SANTHANAM AND SHYAM BALASUBRAMANIAN
HarperCollins India
Price: Rs 195
Pages: 200

| By Sharda Ugra |

It is a banner that is sighted so often on Indian cricket grounds, held up by some young enthusiastic fan hoping to find himself on television and paying tribute to his hero, in third person familiar. "If Cricket Is A Religion, Sachin Is A God." To those who think of themselves as a superior form of cricket connoisseur, the banner is proof of the unthinking, unblinking excessive worship, typical of the Indian cricket fan swept up, poor

charges from influential establishment figures and mainstream media so incensed the authors that they decided to counter them using statistical data just like the critics had done.

Santhanam and Balasubramanian, otherwise completely respectable family men and members of the corporate world, turn into passionate and entertaining defenders of their faith. Friends with an IIT-IIM background, they know how to crunch a mean number and can make a successful presentation of a case which is what they have done in this delightful book. It is an argumentative book but also a joyful one mostly because, along with the numbers, the writers have let their real voices, contemporary and engaged, be heard.

Instantly, the reader is plunged deep into a charged cricket debate that has had its echoes in many a living room, coffee shop, *adda*, *maidan* tent. ("That's ***#@@\$?! Do you even *know* how much he averages outside the subcontinent

chap, in the cult of Sachin Tendulkar

With its title trimmed off the banner, *If Cricket Is A Religion, Sachin Is God* by Vijay Santhanam and Shyam Balasubramanian may sound like a hypernationalistic tract that leaves that no room for debate. It is, in fact, a persuasive argument to convince the non-believers of Tendulkar's quintessential cricketing godliness over 200 pages.

Why, you may wonder, would the converted need 200 pages of preaching. Well inside cricket in recent years, Tendulkar has been subjected to a series of critiques around his monumental run-scoring as well as the nature of his game. Distilled down their essence, the critics have painted Tendulkar as a mere accumulator of numbers, a player with little impact on the fortunes of his team, a batsman who has tempered his game with age due to a fear of failure. These

TENDULKAR POSES WITH HIS WAX STATUE AT MADAME TUSSAUDS MUSEUM



SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE

in the fourth innings chasing a target? In the southern hemisphere?!). The book also takes in neurology, Nietzsche, chess, spirituality and of course, a range of statistics along the way. "If Cricket Is Religion..." contains as pithy and accurate a summary of the history of Indian cricket as you would need to understand Tendulkar in its context. What's the overall conclusion? As if you needed to ask.

By way of tribute to their deity (won't do any good to call him a demigod now, would it?), the authors have offered an abundance of love, data and deep faith.

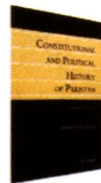
That wax statue in London doesn't even come close. ■



WHY I SUPPORTED THE EMERGENCY: ESSAYS AND PROFILES

by KHUSHWANT SINGH
Edited by SHEELA REDDY
Penguin/Viking
Price: Rs 450
Pages: 296

Features essays on Indira Gandhi's government, 1984 Sikh riots and Nanavati Commission report. This is unadulterated Khushwant Singh.



CONSTITUTIONAL AND POLITICAL HISTORY OF PAKISTAN

by HAMID KHAN
Oxford
Price: Rs 1,295
Pages: 812

An analysis of the constitutional development in Pakistan from its inception.



THE ONLY WAY OUT IS WITHIN

by ROHINI SINGH
Hay House India
Price: Rs 195
Pages: 258

A guide to plugging energy leaks, the book offers simple, practical tools to transform yourself.